

Cinematic Poker

Six characters who bluff, tilt, talk and remember how you play — and a plan that **earns the right to be built before it is built.**

v2 planned a launch. v3 plans a sequence of cheap, killable tests that decide — on evidence — whether the launch should happen, on which platform, and with which product. The objective is unchanged: the largest sustainable long-term audience at self-sustaining economics. The method changes completely, because the three facts v2 rested on no longer hold: the niche is no longer empty, the retention and CPI targets sat above published genre benchmarks, and the acquisition funnel was overstated by roughly 10× at two separate stages.

≤ \$300

SPENT BEFORE THE FIRST DEMAND GATE — \$700 HELD IN RESERVE

3 gates

EACH WITH EXPLICIT PASS AND KILL CRITERIA, EACH CHEAP TO FAIL

Steam first

DISCOVERY MACHINERY; MOBILE SHIPS SECOND, CARRYING THE REPUTATION

1 price

FREE DEMO + SINGLE FULL UNLOCK — NO PACK TREADMILL, NO CHIPS, NO ADS

1 career

STAKES-LADDER SPINE REPLACES SIX AMBIENT ENVIRONMENTS

Wishlists

THE GOVERNING METRIC — THE ONE FUNNEL WITH PUBLIC BENCHMARKS

The core bet, stated honestly: that "RDR2 saloon poker as its own game" converts from a recurring Reddit wish into measurable purchase intent, for original characters, without Rockstar's world around the table. That bet is currently unproven — and the nearest shipped comparable sold almost nothing. So nothing expensive happens until the bet survives Gate 1. If it dies there, total loss is a trailer, a store page, and about three weeks.

Why v2 was rewritten — three findings

1 • The vacuum has closed

v2's wedge — "a decade of demand, zero supply" — is stale. *Poker Night at the Inventory* has been remastered and re-listed on Steam by Skunkape Games. A visible wave of single-player character-poker titles has shipped or been announced: *Pokertown: Cheater's Paradise* (Nov 2025), *Tilting — A Noir Poker Career, Fate & Felt*, and *Project Poker* (Q1 2027 — career mode across five communities, recurring characters, ~2,800 lines of reactive dialogue: essentially our pitch, with more announced content depth).

2 • The nearest comp found no audience

Pokertown — a competent "single-player Hold'em against characters with personalities, with tournament progression" at \$7.99 — has **4 Steam reviews and a tracked concurrent-player peak of 1** after ~11 months on sale: likely low hundreds of copies. One poorly-marketed data point, but it is the closest real-world test of this exact value proposition, and it is sobering. It also reframes what *Poker Night* validated: demand to play poker against *beloved licensed characters*, which original NPCs do not inherit.

3 • The targets sat above published benchmarks

V2 ASSUMPTION	OBSERVED BENCHMARK	CONSEQUENCE
D1 > 35%, D7 = 12% (base case)	Median mobile: D1 ~23%, D7 ~4.2%. Top-quartile card games: ~30% / ~7% / ~1.9% (D28)	Base case assumed top-decile retention; the launch gate would most likely kill the launch
CPI < \$1.50 on poker keywords	US Games median CPI ~\$12; casino-adjacent \$5–\$21+ — chip casinos and real-money apps own the auctions	The Apple Search Ads line fails its own kill rule almost immediately
100k reach → 12k demos → 10k installs	Social CTR <1%; web-demo → store conversion 2–15%. Honest math: 100k impressions → ~1k demos → ~100–300 installs	Both funnel stages overstated ~10×
3% payer conversion · \$8 ARPPU, passive unlocks	Cross-game lifetime IAP conversion ~1.8%; unprompted monetisation converts below norm	Year-1 revenue median nearer \$1–3k than \$5.9k
Tablets: 28% of installs, 1.5× conversion, 37% of revenue	No source; typical tablet install share materially lower	False precision propping up the revenue model
iOS rating 12+	An all-poker app is "frequent simulated gambling" → 17+ on iOS	Ad-placement and discoverability constraints understated

v2's genuinely good idea — small gated tranches with explicit kill rules — is kept, and applied one level up: to the decision to build the product at all, not merely to \$1,000 of launch ads.

Two audiences wearing one trench coat

v2 conflated two different buyers. v3 treats separating them as the first job of validation, because they imply different platforms, different products, and different prices.

A · The nostalgia audience

Loved RDR2's saloon poker; lives on **PC/console**; watches PC-centric creators; buys premium indie games; the itch is partly about *being Arthur in that world* — production values, diegesis, stakes. Reachable through Reddit, YouTube, Steam discovery. Will pay once for a finished thing. Risk: the itch may not transfer to original NPCs on any platform — this is the core bet Gate 1 tests.

B · The offline-utility audience

Searches "offline poker" before flights; lives on **mobile**; high intent to install, *low intent to pay* — they want free poker that works in airplane mode. Reachable through ASO on a low-competition keyword cluster. Monetises poorly against ambience packs; converts best against a single "unlock everything" purchase. A real but modest audience.

Competitive map (October 2026)

COMPETITOR	POSITION	IMPLICATION FOR US
Poker Night (Skunkape remaster)	Licensed-character poker, PC, re-listed	Absorbs nostalgia demand; disproves "zero supply"
Pokertown: Cheater's Paradise	\$7.99 character poker + cheating mechanic, shipped	~4 reviews in 11 months — the niche does not sell itself
Project Poker (Q1 2027)	Career mode, recurring characters, reactive dialogue	Direct concept collision; we must ship differentiation, not claims
Governor of Poker 3 (Playtika)	#2 card game in many markets; ~60–90k installs/mo after a decade	Owns Western-poker shelf on mobile; could clone an "ambience mode" if the niche ever shows revenue
Chip casinos (Zynga, WSOP...)	Resented, enormous	Counter-positioning still works as copy — but it is marketing, not a moat
LLM-driven NPC poker (incoming)	Table-talk opponents via LLMs	Will commoditise "opponents that talk and remember"; our memory must be <i>legible</i> , not just present

Honest sizing

"RDR2 sold 65M" is not a TAM. Real anchors: the category leader on mobile does tens of thousands of installs per month with a decade of ASO and live-ops; shipped indie character-poker on Steam sells hundreds to low thousands of units. Realistic obtainable year-1 audience for a polished new entrant with ~\$1,000 and no following: **3k–15k installs/units**, with a fat right tail if a creator video breaks out. Everything in this plan is sized to that number, not to 37k.

Validate → Steam → Mobile

Steam is first not because it monetises better in theory, but because it has the only functioning zero-budget discovery machinery in games — wishlists, Next Fest, demo culture, "More Like This" — and the only funnel with public benchmarks at every stage. Mobile ships second, carrying the Steam reputation, reviews and creator coverage (the proven premium-card-game sequencing). The web demo survives as a funnel, rebuilt lightweight.

Phase 0 · Validate — ~3–5 weeks, ≤ \$300, minimal new code

Steam "Coming Soon" page + 60s trailer cut from the existing saloon build. Organic developer posts in the recurring "RDR2 poker itch" threads (r/reddeadredemption, r/poker, r/pcgaming) — wishlists are the measurement, not upvotes. In parallel: a three-way framing smoke test (saloon fantasy vs anti-chip-casino vs "poker trainer that reads you") on a landing page with ~\$200 of traffic; stranger playtests of the existing slice; ten Shorts each built on one NPC-memory moment.

GATE 1 — DEMAND

Pass: ≥ 2,500 organic wishlists within ~4 weeks of the Reddit/content push, or one clip organically clearing ~50k views with wishlist lift. **Rework:** 500–2,500 — revisit framing with smoke-test winner, retry once. **Kill:** < 500 — the itch does not convert to intent; stop, having spent ≤ \$300 and three weeks.

Phase 1 · Prove the slice — Next Fest demo + career graybox

Build the **stakes-ladder career graybox** (see §04) into the saloon slice. Enter the next Steam Next Fest with a demo; run the identical slice as a lightweight web/TestFlight build to measure D1/D7 honestly. Creator outreach begins here — in the framing Gate 1's data picked — because now there is a date and a demo to point at.

GATE 2 — PRODUCT

Pass: demo median session > 20 min; ≥ 25% of demo players finish the first career rung; D7 > 7% (top-quartile card benchmark, not v2's 10–12%); testers retell a specific NPC memory moment unprompted. **Kill:** players praise the vibe but do not return — ambience without a spine; do not proceed to full production.

Phase 2 · Launch — Steam premium, then mobile

Steam at **\$11.99** (launch discount to ~\$9.99), wishlist-timed, creator keys two weeks out, the remaining budget deployed on the winning framing. Mobile follows 4–6 months later: free download with the saloon + first career rung, one **\$6.99 full unlock** — targeting the offline-utility ASO cluster with the Steam review score as social proof. Console remains deferred until Steam units justify certification cost.

GATE 3 — EXPANSION

Mobile proceeds if: Steam ≥ 1,500 units in 90 days with ≥ 85% positive reviews. Below that, mobile ships anyway only if Phase 0 showed the offline-utility framing winning — as a modest ASO-led utility product with costs scoped to match.

What "largest sustainable audience" means here: wishlist → launch → review → "More Like This" compounds on Steam in a way App Store long-tail listings never do. Audience built there transfers to mobile; the reverse is not true at this budget.

One place, deep — with a career spine

The stakes-ladder career (new, load-bearing)

Every comparable that retained players has one: GoP 1–2's campaign map, Pokertown's tournaments, Tilting's career, Project Poker's five communities. v3 makes it the spine: start at the kitchen table, earn a seat at the saloon's back room, climb to the high-stakes game. Rungs gate NPCs, stakes and story beats. Ambience is a 20-minute novelty; a career is a reason to return on day 7 — and it is what the single purchase unlocks.

Legible memory, not invisible parameters

VPIP/PFR opponent modelling is real engineering a casual player cannot perceive and a strong player will find the seams of. The differentiator that can be *seen* — and filmed — is memory surfacing in behaviour: an NPC who references the hand where you bluffed him last week, a rival who tightens up only against you, a grudge that changes table talk. Design rule: **every memory feature must be able to star in a 15-second vertical clip**. "The NPC remembered" is the marketing unit of the entire plan (\$05), so the product must manufacture those moments reliably.

Scope discipline

V2 SCOPE	V3 SCOPE
6+ environments on a 6–8 week treadmill, ~30 NPCs	One saloon, five NPCs with genuine depth; a second environment only as a post-launch career chapter if attach data justifies it
Parallel Blazor web build claimed as "the identical engine" alongside a Unity project	One engine. The web demo is either a true build target of it or a deliberately thin teaser — never a second codebase to maintain
Coaching as a pillar and second audience	Coaching kept as a retention layer and review-quote generator ("it made me better at poker") — not a separate marketing front until the core sells
Tablet presentation pass, iPad-specific ASO surface at launch	Deferred to the mobile phase, sized by real device-mix data from the demo

Measurement vs privacy — resolved, not claimed

v2 promised an iOS "Data Not Collected" label and a weekly funnel dashboard; those conflict. v3's choice: minimal first-party, on-device-aggregated telemetry disclosed plainly ("anonymous play statistics, nothing sold, no third parties"), keeping honest D1/D7/D30 measurement. The ethical-monetisation story survives on its strongest leg — no chips, no ads, no account — without a privacy claim the analytics would contradict.

One price, one promise — and a budget that waits

Pricing

ITEM	PRICE
Steam — full game	\$11.99 (launch −15%)
Steam/web demo — saloon + first career rung	Free
Mobile — download (saloon + rung one)	Free
Mobile — full unlock (one-time IAP)	\$6.99
Supporter tip ("buy the dealer a whisky")	\$2.99
Career-chapter expansions (post-launch, data-gated)	\$4.99

No chips, no ads, no gacha, no subscriptions — unchanged, and still the best copy we own. Gone: the pack treadmill and the \$14.99 "all future content" edition that capped our best customers while obligating infinite delivery.

The \$1,000, re-sequenced

LINE	\$	WHEN	GATE
Trailer & store assets (cut from existing build)	100	Phase 0	Exists before any spend
Framing smoke test (3 creatives → landing page)	200	Phase 0	Winner by cost-per-signup; also tests ad-policy clearance
Creator seeding — in the winning frame only	350	Phase 1–2, after Gate 1	Keys + \$50–75 to the 5–6 best fits; measure wishlist lift per video, not video count
Launch-week reserve (doubles down on what moved wishlists)	250	Phase 2	Deployed only against a channel with demonstrated lift
Apple Search Ads probe — "offline poker" exact-match cluster	100	Mobile phase	A pricing probe, not acquisition; kill at CPI > \$3 with no unlock conversions

Still deliberately \$0: broad UA, press agencies, paid reviews, feature brokers. Still free and primary: Reddit presence as a developer in the itch threads, twice-weekly devlogs built on NPC-memory clips, press kit, Next Fest.

Why single-unlock beats packs

Ambience packs are cosmetic-DLC economics (low attach) without a whale ceiling; and the audience that arrives via "offline poker" search wants a complete thing for one price — the GoP 1–2 formula v2 itself called beloved. A demo-to-unlock funnel converts the product's actual strength (try the table, meet the characters, hit the career gate, pay once). Payer math is sized honestly: mobile conversion 1.5–2.5% of installs at a \$6.99 ticket, not 3% × \$8 of passive pack attach.

Ratings reality

Planned for 17+ on iOS (frequent simulated gambling) and Teen on Google Play from day one; creatives lead with "no real money — ever" to clear ad-policy screens, with organic channels as the primary path where paid poker creatives are blocked.

Ordered by how much uncertainty each removes

#	EXPERIMENT	COST · TIME	PASS / KILL	UNCERTAINTY REMOVED
1	Steam Coming Soon page + organic Reddit demand test in the itch threads	~\$100 · 3 wks	≥2,500 organic wishlists pass · <500 kill	Does the market exist at all? The single biggest unknown, removed for the price of a trailer
2	Framing smoke test — saloon fantasy vs anti-chip-casino vs poker trainer	~\$200 · 2 wks	Winner by cost-per-signup; any frame blocked by ad policy is noted	Positioning — which promise pulls, and whether poker creatives clear paid channels
3	Stranger playtest, hardened — 15–20 players, existing slice	\$0 · 2 wks	Unprompted day-2 return + players retell a specific NPC memory moment	Is the differentiator perceivable and fun — or just parameters?
4	Clip-virality probe — ten Shorts, each one NPC-memory moment	\$0 · 4 wks	≥1 clip clears ~50k organic views	Content marketability — the silent dependency of the whole creator strategy
5	Steam Next Fest demo	\$0 · fest cycle	Demo → wishlist conversion vs public benchmarks; session > 20 min	Conversion — after this, launch revenue is forecastable within ~2×
6	Career-graybox retention probe (demo cohort, with/without ladder)	~2–3 wks dev	D7 > 7% with ladder; measurable lift over ambience-only build	The retention spine — settles environments-vs-career with data before full production
7	Apple Search Ads keyword probe, "offline poker" cluster	\$100 · 1 wk	Confirm real CPI; kill > \$3 with zero unlock conversions	Mobile channel pricing — smallest unknown, hence last

Experiments 1–4 run before significant new development. Experiment 6 is the only one that costs real build time — and the one that decides what the product is.

Risk register (what v2 missed or understated)

RISK	MITIGATION
Core bet fails — nostalgia doesn't transfer to original NPCs	Gate 1 kills for ≤ \$300; the saloon slice survives as a portfolio piece
Project Poker (Q1 2027) ships first with more content	Be earlier where it counts: Next Fest, memory-moment clip language it isn't using; depth-per-NPC over NPC count
LLM table-talk commoditises "characters that remember"	Moats shift to craft + community: authored grudges, career stakes, build-in-public following
IP exposure (Take-Two is litigious)	No marks in owned copy; creator briefs never instruct an RDR2 comparison; FTC disclosure on paid placements
Paid poker creatives blocked by gambling policies	Organic-first; "no real money — ever" leads every creative; smoke test surfaces blocks in week 2, not launch week
Labor ROI — months of dev vs low-thousands revenue median	The gate structure is the mitigation: each phase risks weeks, not the year

Honest projections — distributions, not a base case

v2 labelled a top-quartile outcome "base." v3 states percentiles, conditioned on passing the gates. If Gate 1 fails, the plan's outcome is **−\$300 and three weeks** — which is the entire point.

HORIZON	P10 — IT LANDS QUIETLY	P50 — IT WORKS MODESTLY	P90 — A VIDEO BREAKS OUT
12 months	Gate 2 passed but launch misses: 600–1,200 Steam units, mobile deferred. ~\$5–9k gross; labor-negative; audience ~1–2k.	2,500–5,000 Steam units at ~\$11 avg net-of-cut ≈ \$20–40k gross revenue; mobile port greenlit; audience 5–10k with an active community hub.	15k+ units, strong reviews compound discovery; \$100k+ gross; mobile launches into an existing audience.
24 months	Long tail ~\$200–500/mo across both stores; decide: sunset or one career-chapter swing.	Mobile adds 10–40k installs at 1.5–2.5% unlock conversion; first paid chapter ships to proven attach; cumulative \$40–80k; audience 25–60k.	Franchise footing: chapters sustain beats, console port now justified by data; cumulative \$150k+.
36 months	Archived or minimal-maintenance; total loss bounded at phase budgets.	A durable niche product: 50–100k lifetime audience, \$1–3k/mo steady — self-sustaining economics on the stated objective.	Category ownership of "character poker"; the audience, not the revenue, is the asset — sequel/expansion optionality.

What would change this plan

- **Gate 1 wishlists arrive mostly from "offline poker" framing, not nostalgia** → invert back to mobile-first as a premium-unlock utility, scoped small; Steam becomes the later port.
- **Project Poker's launch visibly saturates the Steam niche before our Next Fest** → differentiate harder on the memory/grudge system and mobile timing; consider leap-frogging to the mobile audience it won't serve.
- **A clip format repeatedly breaks out** → shift budget from creator seeding to producing that format in volume; content-led acquisition beats paid at this scale.

Summary. Keep the fantasy, the ethics, and the kill-rule discipline. Replace the assumed funnel with a measured one, the pack treadmill with one honest price, the six ambient places with one career that creates filmable memory-moments — and spend the first dollars proving that anyone wishlists this before spending the year building it.